

Abuse, Neglect, Exploitation & Professional Boundaries

Safeguarding adults with disability and maintaining safe worker relationships

Suggested training type: Read + mini quiz Suggested pass mark: 80% Review/validity: 12 months recommended review cycle

Learning objectives

- Recognise common forms and warning signs of abuse, neglect and exploitation.
- Know how to respond to disclosures without investigating beyond your role.
- Maintain professional, financial, social and sexual boundaries.
- Escalate concerns promptly.

1. Safeguarding obligation

NDIS workers must take reasonable steps to prevent and respond to violence, exploitation, neglect, abuse and sexual misconduct. Concerns can be obvious or subtle and can involve workers, family, acquaintances, strangers or others.

2. Possible forms of harm

- Physical abuse or rough handling.
- Psychological or emotional abuse, threats, intimidation or humiliation.
- Sexual abuse, harassment or sexual misconduct.
- Financial exploitation, theft, coercion or pressure around money.
- Neglect of basic support, health, hygiene, nutrition or safety needs.
- Coercive control, isolation, restriction or exploitation of dependence.

3. Responding to a disclosure

Stay calm, listen, take the person seriously, check immediate safety, avoid leading questions, do not promise secrecy, record the person's words accurately where possible, and escalate immediately through the approved safeguarding/incident process. Do not conduct your own investigation.

4. Professional boundaries

- Do not borrow money, accept inappropriate gifts or ask participants for loans.
- Do not use a participant's money, card, account or property outside authorised support arrangements.
- Do not begin sexual or exploitative relationships with participants.
- Do not post participant information, images or stories on social media.
- Do not use personal relationships to pressure a participant into choices.

- Ask a supervisor when cultural expectations, gifts, friendships or family relationships create uncertainty.

5. Free NSW training

The NSW Ageing and Disability Commission provides free training modules on detecting and responding to abuse, neglect and exploitation in family, home and community settings, with downloadable resources and completion certificates. Opus Care can require these as external training and track the certificates.

Knowledge Check

Choose the best answer for each question. Suggested pass mark: 80%. This quiz checks understanding of the module; it does not replace supervised practical competency where that is required.

1. What should a worker do after a participant discloses possible abuse?

- A. Investigate suspects personally
- B. Listen, check immediate safety, record and escalate
- C. Promise absolute secrecy
- D. Ignore it unless there is visible injury

2. Which is a professional-boundary concern?

- A. Following an agreed support plan
- B. Borrowing money from a participant
- C. Using the CRM
- D. Asking a supervisor for guidance

3. Who can be responsible for abuse or exploitation?

- A. Only paid workers
- B. Only family
- C. Many different people, including workers, family, acquaintances or others
- D. Only strangers

4. Should a worker use leading questions to obtain more evidence?

- A. Yes
- B. No - the worker should listen and report, not conduct an investigation
- C. Only at night
- D. Only when no manager is available

5. Which external NSW resource offers free safeguarding training?

- A. NSW Ageing and Disability Commission
- B. A random blog
- C. A shopping website
- D. A bank

Manager answer key is included in the accompanying quiz JSON file.

Source and reference notes

This Opus Care resource is an original internal training summary. It is based on current public guidance and does not reproduce third-party courses. Workers should use the linked official resources where specified.

- <https://www.ndiscommission.gov.au/rules-and-standards/ndis-code-conduct>
- <https://ageingdisabilitycommission.nsw.gov.au/tools-and-resources/training/module-one.html>
- <https://ageingdisabilitycommission.nsw.gov.au/tools-and-resources/training/module-two/module-two-training.html>

Important: Internal completion does not create a nationally recognised qualification, professional licence, or practical competency. Opus Care should verify external qualifications and practical skills appropriate to each worker's role and the supports actually delivered.